

INTEGRITY RECORDS

BOND OF PEACE

*Choosing Meekness, Unity, and Love
on Purpose*

*“Make every effort to keep the unity of the Spirit
through the bond of peace.”*

EPHESIANS 4:3

BOND OF PEACE

Choosing Meekness, Unity, and Love on Purpose

© Chris Johnson. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the publisher, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

Scripture quotations taken from the Holy Bible unless otherwise noted.

Integrity Records — Texas

integrityrecords.org

Table of Contents

Introduction — The Effort Behind the Bond	5
Chapter One — Blessed Are the Meek	7
Chapter Two — With All Humility and Gentleness	10
Chapter Three — Bearing With One Another in Love	13
Chapter Four — The Bond That Holds	16
Chapter Five — How Good and Pleasant	19
Chapter Six — One Body, Many Parts	22
Chapter Seven — Love on Purpose	25
Closing Word	28

INTRODUCTION

The Effort Behind the Bond

“As a prisoner for the Lord, then, I urge you to live a life worthy of the calling you have received. Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love. Make every effort to keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace.”

EPHESIANS 4:1-3

Paul does not say unity happens naturally among people who love God. He says to make every effort to keep it — language that assumes unity is fragile, costly, and constantly under pressure to fracture. The bond of peace is not the absence of conflict. It's a bond, something actively held, the way two hands hold something that would otherwise fall apart.

This is especially true for anyone working closely with other people toward a shared calling — a band, a worship team, a label, a ministry. Unity among gifted, passionate people is not automatic. It is chosen, repeatedly, often at real cost to pride and preference. This book is about what Paul says that choice actually requires: meekness, humility, patient love, and a bond deliberately kept rather than passively assumed.

Peace is not the absence of tension. It's a bond deliberately held while the tension is still there.

CHAPTER ONE

Blessed Are the Meek

“Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth.”

MATTHEW 5:5

Meekness is one of the most misunderstood words in Scripture, routinely confused with weakness, timidity, or an inability to stand up for oneself. The biblical picture is different: meekness is strength held under control, power that has been deliberately submitted rather than power that never existed in the first place. Moses is called the meekest man on earth in the same book where he confronts Pharaoh. Jesus describes Himself as meek and lowly in heart while overturning tables in the temple.

Meekness, then, is not the absence of strength, conviction, or gift. It is strength that has chosen not to dominate. For anyone with real talent, a real platform, or real influence over a team, this is the specific discipline meekness requires: the deliberate choice not to use available power — of personality, gift, or position — to force an outcome, even when it could be forced.

Meekness is not the absence of strength. It's strength that has already decided not to use itself against you.

Why meekness is the foundation, not an afterthought

Paul places humility and gentleness first in his list, before patience and unity, because unity is nearly impossible to sustain among people who are each quietly convinced their own strength entitles them to the final word. A team full of gifted, ungoverned strength fractures. A team full of gifted, meek strength can actually hold together, because each person has already decided not to win every disagreement just because they could.

REFLECTION

Where in your working relationships do you have real strength you've chosen — or not yet chosen — not to use to force an outcome?

What would meekness, rightly understood as governed strength, look like in your next disagreement with a collaborator?

CHAPTER TWO

With All Humility and Gentleness

Paul pairs humility and gentleness deliberately, because each one guards against a different failure. Humility corrects an inflated view of your own importance in the room. Gentleness corrects a harsh way of handling other people's failures once that inflated view has already been set aside.

It's possible to be theoretically humble — genuinely aware that you're not the center of everything — and still handle other people roughly, impatiently, or dismissively. Gentleness is what humility looks like in the actual texture of how you speak to someone who has just made a mistake, missed a cue, or disagreed with your creative direction.

Gentleness under pressure

The real test of gentleness rarely shows up in calm moments. It shows up when a rehearsal is behind schedule, a mix isn't working, or a collaborator has just made the exact mistake you warned them about. Gentleness in that moment isn't the absence of correction — it's correction delivered by someone who has not stopped seeing the other person as valuable while delivering it.

- Notice the tone you default to under deadline pressure, not just in relaxed conversation.
- Ask whether your correction of others aims at their improvement or simply at relieving your own frustration.
- Practice naming a mistake without attaching it to the person's whole character or worth.

Gentleness is not measured by how you treat people when everything is going well. It's measured by how you treat them when it isn't.

REFLECTION

How do you tend to treat people differently under pressure than you do when things are calm?

Who in your working life would benefit most from a gentler version of your correction this week?

CHAPTER THREE

Bearing With One Another in Love

“Be patient, bearing with one another in love.”

EPHESIANS 4:2

Bearing with someone is different from merely tolerating them. Tolerance can be entirely passive — simply not acting on the irritation. Bearing with someone, in the sense Paul means, is active: it's continuing to extend love toward a person specifically in the space where they are difficult to love, rather than waiting for them to become easier first.

This matters enormously in any long-term working relationship — a band that tours together, a team that rehearses weekly, a label and its artists. Every one of those relationships will, eventually, require bearing with something genuinely irritating in another person, repeatedly, without that irritation becoming the whole of how you see them.

What bearing with someone does not mean

This is not a call to bear with abuse, manipulation, or ongoing sin left unaddressed. Scripture elsewhere is direct about confronting real wrongs. Bearing with one another in love describes the ordinary friction of imperfect people working closely together — differing habits, differing paces, differing communication styles — not a license to ignore genuine harm.

- Distinguish between an annoying habit worth bearing with and a genuine harm that needs to be addressed directly.
- Ask whether your patience with someone has quietly curdled into resentment you've never actually named to them.
- Practice extending the same patience to a collaborator's tenth mistake that you extended to their first.

REFLECTION

Who in your working life have you stopped genuinely bearing with, even if you're still technically tolerating them?

What's the difference, honestly, between something you should keep bearing with and something you actually need to address?

CHAPTER FOUR

The Bond That Holds

“Make every effort to keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace.”

EPHESIANS 4:3

“And over all these virtues put on love, which binds them all together in perfect unity.”

COLOSSIANS 3:14

Paul uses the same picture in both letters: a bond, something that holds separate things together. In Ephesians, it's peace that binds. In Colossians, it's love, described as the outer garment that holds every other virtue in place, the way a belt holds a loose robe together into something wearable.

Without this bond, every other virtue Paul has just listed — humility, gentleness, patience — can exist individually in a group of people and still never cohere into actual unity. A team can be individually humble and still fractured, individually patient and still divided, if nothing is actively binding those virtues together into a shared bond.

Love isn't one virtue among many here. It's the belt that holds all the others in place.

A bond is maintained, not assumed

The word bond implies something that requires maintenance — a rope can fray, a knot can loosen. Unity of the Spirit is not a static achievement reached once and preserved automatically afterward. It's tended, the way any bond between people is tended: through regular honesty, regular forgiveness, and a shared decision, renewed often, to stay bound together rather than drift apart.

REFLECTION

Where is the bond of peace in your team or relationships currently fraying, even quietly?

What would it look like to actively re-tie that bond this week, rather than assuming it will hold on its own?

CHAPTER FIVE

How Good and Pleasant

“How good and pleasant it is when God's people live together in unity! It is like precious oil poured on the head, running down on the beard, running down on Aaron's beard, down on the collar of his robe.”

PSALM 133:1-2

This psalm describes unity not as an obligation to be endured but as a genuine blessing to be enjoyed — pleasant, like abundant oil, like dew. The image of oil running down from head to beard to collar suggests something overflowing, generous, and consecrating: unity here is connected directly to anointing, to the presence and blessing of God resting visibly on His people.

This reframes unity as something worth actively wanting, not merely something owed out of obligation. A team that has genuinely pursued the bond of peace doesn't just avoid the pain of division — they get to experience something Scripture describes as actively good and pleasant, an overflow that blesses everyone within reach of it.

Unity was never presented in Scripture as a chore to endure. It was presented as oil running down, generous enough to reach everyone in the room.

What this changes practically

If unity is genuinely pleasant rather than merely dutiful, then pursuing it isn't only about avoiding conflict — it's about actively cultivating something worth wanting. A band, a team, or a label that has fought for real unity should expect, according to this psalm, an actual, tangible blessing on the other side of that effort, not just the relief of not fighting.

REFLECTION

Have you experienced unity as genuinely pleasant, the way Psalm 133 describes, or only as an obligation to maintain?

What would it look like to actively pursue unity as a blessing worth wanting, rather than a conflict merely to be avoided?

CHAPTER SIX

One Body, Many Parts

“Just as a body, though one, has many parts, but all its many parts form one body, so it is with Christ... If one part suffers, every part suffers with it; if one part is honored, every part rejoices with it.”

1 CORINTHIANS 12:12, 26

Paul's body imagery is directly relevant to any team of gifted people working toward a shared calling. The parts of a body are not identical, and unity does not require them to become identical. A hand does not need to function like an eye for the body to be unified. Unity, in this picture, is precisely the coordinated function of genuinely different parts toward a shared purpose.

Diversity of gifting is not the threat to unity

This corrects a common misunderstanding: unity is sometimes pursued by flattening differences, as though the safest team is the one where everyone thinks, plays, and contributes identically. Paul says the opposite. The threat to unity isn't difference — it's a part of the body deciding it doesn't belong because it's different, or a part deciding another part is unnecessary because it functions differently.

“The eye cannot say to the hand, 'I don't need you!' And the head cannot say to the feet, 'I don't need you!'”

1 CORINTHIANS 12:21

Unity was never meant to erase difference. It was meant to coordinate it toward one purpose.

- Notice whether your team treats different gifts and roles as equally necessary, or quietly ranks some as more valuable.
- Practice genuinely rejoicing when a different part of your team is honored, rather than only when your own contribution is noticed.
- Resist the temptation to wish other people's gifts were more like your own.

REFLECTION

Is there a part of your team you've quietly treated as less necessary because their gift looks different from yours?

What would it look like this week to actively honor a gift in your team that's different from your own?

CHAPTER SEVEN

Love on Purpose

“Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud... It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres.”

1 CORINTHIANS 13:4, 7

Paul's description of love here is entirely a description of behavior, not a description of a feeling. Patient, kind, not envious, not proud, protecting, trusting, hoping, persevering — every one of these is a choice available regardless of what emotion happens to be present at the moment. This is what it means to love on purpose: love as a decision, renewed daily, rather than love as a feeling you either happen to have or don't.

This matters enormously in the ordinary friction of working closely with other people over years. Feelings of warmth toward a collaborator will naturally rise and fall with mood, stress, and circumstance. If love is only the feeling, unity becomes hostage to whatever mood is currently present. If love is a decision, it remains available precisely on the days the feeling is absent — which are usually the days unity needs it the most.

Love on purpose doesn't wait for the feeling to show up first. It shows up, and often the feeling follows behind it.

Choosing love in the specific moment of friction

- In your next disagreement, ask what patient, kind, and not proud would actually require you to do, regardless of what you feel like doing.
- Choose to trust a collaborator's intentions even when their execution has disappointed you.
- Persevere with a relationship past the point where the initial warmth has worn thin.

This is the whole of the bond of peace, gathered into a single, repeatable choice: meekness that governs your strength, gentleness that governs your correction, patience that bears with what's difficult, and love, chosen on purpose, that holds every other virtue together into something that actually lasts.

REFLECTION

Where in your life is love currently waiting on a feeling that hasn't shown up?

What would it look like to choose love on purpose there this week, regardless of the feeling?

CLOSING WORD

Keep the Bond

Paul's instruction was never make unity, as though it could be manufactured once and left alone. It was keep the unity of the Spirit through the bond of peace — ongoing language, for an ongoing bond, held together by people who keep choosing meekness over dominance, gentleness over harshness, patience over resentment, and love over whatever feeling happens to be present that day.

That bond, kept, is not a burden to endure. Scripture calls it good and pleasant, oil running down, a blessing generous enough to reach everyone within it. Whatever team, band, or calling you're building alongside other people, that bond is available to you the same way it was available to the church Paul was writing to — through effort, through meekness, and through love chosen on purpose, one day at a time.

INTEGRITY RECORDS

integrityrecords.org